

In response, she asked me, “What are some of the current challenges we all face in life?” We started naming them. We’re busy, stressed, tired, lacking connection. Challenges I didn’t think had anything to do with gardening. But she went through every challenge we listed off and explained how gardening solved for each one. How being outside reduces cortisol levels, thereby decreasing stress, the ways sunshine increases our energy levels and enhances our mood, and that this simple way of producing veggies at home invites neighbors, kids, and friends into the yard to participate, giving us some much-needed human connection. By the end of the interview, I was picturing myself in my garden, resting in something I’d cared for with my own hands, physically reconnecting with the earth, spending meaningful time with my sons as they witnessed seeds transform and learn how food grows, and eating nutritious food that came from my backyard.

Nicole went on to explain that for most people who don’t garden yet, they’ll say it’s because they don’t have a green thumb, don’t have enough space, not enough sun, not enough time, not enough money, whatever. But what it really boils down to is that they just don’t see the value in it. Why put in all the hard work, fight the bugs and plant rot, just to have a mediocre zucchini that you could’ve bought at the grocery store for far less effort, assuming you’d even have chosen to buy zucchini at all? *It’s impossible to stick with it if you don’t find enough value in the practice to dedicate yourself to learning the skill.* Instead, Nicole invited me to practice gardening not for what it could produce for me but for how it could serve my internal needs.

In his book *Drive*, Daniel Pink looks at studies done at MIT and other universities about what motivates us to do things. He found that external rewards like money or the avoidance of punishment only resulted in better performance in basic tasks, such as getting yourself a little treat for getting through the day or doing the dishes to avoid ticking off your roommate. The studies found that if the task involved cognitive skills like decision-making, innovation, and creativity, internal motivators were far more effective than external. Internal motivation means that your motivation to accomplish something comes from within you. There’s no treat or punishment driving you, you simply want to do it.

Values-based spending, like gardening, isn’t a basic task. It’s a creative act full of decision-making, innovation, and creativity. And if you want to master it, you have to be internally motivated to do it. You have to value not